College Bound

ISSUES & TRENDS FOR THE COLLEGE ADMISSIONS ADVISOR

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Year-end Roundup

Fall Enrollment Trends

THE FALL 2025 total enrollment at the nation's postsecondary institutions grew by more than 2 percent over last year, according to the preliminary report from the National Student Clearinghouse Research Center. Estimates are based on reports from half of all institutions.

Total undergraduate enrollment increased by 2.4 percent. At community colleges, enrollment jumped by 4 percent. At public four-year institutions, it rose by 1.9 percent. And at private four-year schools, it edged up by only 0.9 percent. Undergraduate and graduate certificate programs recorded the largest growth, 6.6 percent.

Undergraduate enrollment among 18-year-old students is up 3.2 percent. Adult students 25-29 years-old grew by 2.7 percent, while those 30 years and older were up by 2.7 percent. More undergraduate Hispanic, black and multi-racial students enrolled, while enrollment for white students fell by 3.7 percent.

Of significance is the fact that students majoring in computer and information science plunged by 7.7 percent for undergraduates and 15 percent for graduate students at four-year institutions.

International Enrollment Declines Slightly. According to the "Open Doors 2025 Report" from the Institute of International Education, international students account for 6.1 percent of the total U.S. higher education population of 19,247,640 students. This Fall 2025, after significant problems with visas and anti-immigrant rhetoric, Open Doors data from 900 institutions indicates that total international student enrollment fell by 1 percent.

However, while undergraduate enrollment increased by 2 percent, graduate school enrollment declined by 12 percent. And new enrollment of international students skidded by 17 percent.

Altogether, international students contributed about $55 billion to the U.S. economy during the 2024-25 school year. The decline for the 2025-26 academic year is projected to cost the U.S. $1.1 billion. The implications are still being played out in colleges and universities and their surrounding cities and towns.

"International students do far more than attend classes, they sustain local economies," Bjorn Markeson, an economist at Implan, an economic software and analysis company, told CNBC.

In 2024-25, new international student enrollment at U.S. colleges and universities had already slid by 7.2 percent to 277,118 from 298,705. However, total international student enrollment grew by 4.5 percent, up from 1,126,690 to 1,177,766. India, followed by China, sent the most international students.

California hosts the most international students, followed by New York, Texas, Massachusetts, Illinois, Pennsylvania, Florida, Michigan, Ohio and Missouri.

Their top fields of study are math and computer science, engineering, business and management, physical and life sciences, social sciences, fine and applied arts, health professions, as well as communications and journalism.

Meanwhile, in the 2023-24 academic year, the number of U.S. students studying abroad for academic credit grew by 6 percent to 298,180. Most popular destinations? Italy, Spain, United Kingdom, France, Japan, Ireland, Germany, Greece and Australia.

African American Enrollment Is "Waning" at Elite Colleges After Supreme Court Ruling. An Associated Press analysis of

continued on page 2

Financial Matters

College Pricing. The College Board's "College Pricing 2025" report found that the average published (sticker) tuition and fees for full-time, in-state undergraduate students at public four-year institutions stood at $11,950, up $340 from the previous year (2.9 percent before adjusting for inflation.) For out-of-state students it was an average of $31,880, $1,060 higher than the previous year, or 3.4 percent.

The average cost for in-district students at public two-year schools was $4,150, $110 higher than 2024-25. At private nonprofit four-year colleges and universities, the cost was $45,000, $1,750 higher than the year before.

The report also found that the majority of full-time undergraduate students receive grant aid. "On average, first-time full-time students at public two-year colleges have been receiving enough grant aid to cover their tuition and fees since 2009-10."

Additionally, "After adjusting for inflation, the average net tuition and fees paid by first-time full-time in-state students enrolled in public four-year institutions peaked in 2012-13 at $4,450 (in 2025 dollars) and declined to an estimated $2,300 in 2025-26."

And "After adjusting for inflation, the average net tuition and fees paid by first-time full-time students enrolled in private nonprofit four-year institutions declined from $19,810 (in 2025 dollars) in 2006-07 to an estimated $16,910 in 2025-26."

Where Does College Cost Less? Cost More? According to an analysis by Wallethub, the 10 states where college is least expensive, all

continued on page 2

INSIDE

- **More Enrollment Trends**
- **Financial Matters, Books**
- **Curriculum Capsules**
- **And… News You Can Use**

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Enrollment Trends

continued from page 1

enrollment numbers at 20 elite institutions found that black enrollment is "wanning at many elite colleges after affirmative action ban."

For example, since 2023, black enrollment is down at Columbia U. from 20 percent to 13 percent; at Harvard U. from 18 percent to 11.5 percent; at Emory U. from 13 percent to 11 percent; at Yale U. from 9.5 percent to 8 percent; at the U. of North Carolina from 10 percent to 7.8 percent; at the U. of Virginia, it fell from 8.1 percent to 6 percent; at the U. of Southern California, it fell from 7.8 percent to 6 percent; at the California Institute of Technology, it fell from 5 percent to 1.6 percent and at Williams, it fell from 6.8 percent to 4.7 percent.

According to the AP, Smith C. in Massachusetts was the only elite school that registered a gain. Its black student enrollment rose from 4.6 percent to 6.8 percent.

"It feels like we're being set back in time, and it's heartbreaking to see," Princeton junior Kennedy Beal told the *Milwaukee Independent*. "But at the same time, I still have faith that we will persevere. We will continue to demonstrate our excellence in these institutions."

See, http://apnews.com.

Colorado's Community Colleges Set Fall Record. Enrollment at Colorado's 13 community colleges increased by 6.3 percent, with 1,000 students more than last fall. The state's C.C. system enrolled 94,303 students. While more adults and recent high school graduates are attending the community colleges, enrollment growth has been driven by high school student dual enrollment. More than 3,400 students 17 years and younger are enrolled this fall.

"What I've seen is that more aligned industry and workforce-driven things are what's growing in a lot of community college spaces here," Sarah Heath, Colorado Community College System Vice Chancellor, told *Sentinel Colorado*.

Individual College's Posting Enrollment

Bridgewater C. Students Come from 17 States. Bridgewater C. in Virginia greeted 527 new students this fall, all of whom receive financial aid. That number includes 72 transfer students, many from Blue Ridge C.C. in nearby Weyers Cave. First-generation students account for 37 percent of the new class. About 13 percent were welcomed into BC's honors program.

Altogether though, new students hail from 17 different states. The top majors of new students are business administration, health and exercise science, biology, elementary education and engineering. They can also choose from three new majors: criminology, game design and international security and diplomacy.

Central Washington Enrollment Falls. In Ellensburg, Washington, enrollment at Central Washington U. declined by 2.3 percent or about 200 students. Last fall, it enrolled 8,509 students, this fall 8,309, about 1,600 of whom are freshmen. About 95 percent come from the State of Washington. Central Washington's first-to-second year retention rate is 73 percent.

Cornell's Largest Class. Cornell U.'s Class of 2029 is the largest in school history at 3,827 students, an 8.6 percent increase from last year.

Cornell did not collect demographic data during its admissions process. But it did so this fall after students enrolled. Its BHI (Black, Hispanic, American Indian) category increased from 15.7 percent last year to 18 percent this fall. But that is significantly lower since the Supreme Court affirmative action ruling. It fell from 25.4 percent for the Class of 2027. The number of white students also declined from 32.1 percent last year to 30 percent this fall.

Georgia's Record New Class. The U. of Georgia enrolled 6,200 first year students culled from nearly 48,000 applicants. Georgia's acceptance rate is now 33 percent. The class hails from 15 nations and 45 states.

New students posted an average high school GPA of 4.17, SATs of 1356 and ACTs of 31. They took an average 11 Advanced Placement, International Baccalaureate or dual enrollment classes.

(Georgia also announced that its new school of nursing will open in Fall 2027.)

Missouri State Retains 76 Percent. This fall, enrollment at the Springfield campus of Missouri State U. hit 25,238, despite fewer graduate and international students. International enrollment accounts for 5.7 percent of the student body, down from 6.9 percent last fall. MSU is the state's second largest postsecondary institution. It credits dual enrollment, transfers and a 76 percent retention rate for its fall record. Dual enrollment of high school students increased 9.1 percent to 7,778 students. Enrollment was also up 2.8 percent at MSU's West Plains campus.

"Faculty and advisors are focused on student success and retention in every college," said Clarenda Philips, provost.

Montana Retains 77 Percent. This year, the U. of Montana set a retention record of 77.2 percent for students moving from first-to-second year. In Fall 2025, more than 11,000 students enrolled in UM credit courses, and it served another 10,387 individuals through noncredit courses to help them "reskill, upskill or change careers."

"In today's rapidly changing labor market, everyone deserves access to education that meets their specific needs and is delivered on their timeline," a university spokesperson told *Daily Inter Lake*.

Puget Sound "Falls Short." The U. of Puget Sound in Tacoma, Washington, enrolled 380 students in its Class of 2029, 12 percent fewer than last year. A decade ago, enrollment reached 652 students. Since 78 percent of the university's budget comes from tuition, the school is now running a deficit.

However, PSU President Isiaah Crawford told *The Trail*, "We've made necessary expense reductions across the university where we could, but we've been doing that in a way that we believe does not undermine the quality of the educational experience that we've been able to provide students."

Stanford U. Enrolls 90 Transfers. Stanford U. in Palo Alto, California, enrolled 1,866 new students in its Class of 2029, its largest first-year class in years. It also welcomed 90 transfer students from 76 colleges and universities including 36 from community colleges. About 19 percent are eligible for Pell Grants and 20 percent are first in their family to attend college. New students traveled from 65 countries and speak 81 languages at home.

Just over 12 percent self-identify as Hispanic, 5.8 as black, 3 percent as American Indian, 43.9 percent as Asian American, 42.1 as white and 12.7 percent as international students.

Stanford admissions representatives attended more than 1,100 high school and community organization events.

Sweet Briar C. Loses International Students. Sweet Briar C. enrollment dropped to 373 compared to 438 in Fall 2024. President Mary Pope Hutson told alumni on a Zoom Q&A in early September that low enrollment was due primarily to international students who couldn't get visas in time for the fall semester. Last fall, 8 percent of students came from outside the U.S. This fall, that rate was 5.4 percent.

continued on page 4

Financial Matters

continued from page 1

things considered, are: Utah, North Dakota, Wyoming, Hawaii, Nevada, South Dakota, Maryland, Colorado, Delaware and Idaho.

The states where it is most expensive are Pennsylvania, Rhode Island, New York, Massachusetts, Illinois, Vermont, Connecticut, Louisiana, Oregon and Ohio. ■

The Counselor's Corner

Outlook for 2026

California State's Direct Admissions Program. A new state law going into effect this January 1 establishes a Direct Admission Program for California State U. The new procedure builds off a pilot last year at CSU Riverside. Now, all California high school students who meet the system's requirements will automatically receive an admissions letter to all 16 CSU campuses.

The law comes at a time when CSU is experiencing declining enrollment and will initially roll out to 43 school districts and will expand statewide.

Columbia U. May Expand Undergraduate Admissions. Columbia U. in New York City is considering expanding its undergraduate student body by as much as 20 percent, according to the *Columbia Spectator.*

The Ivy League school is said to have experienced financial losses during the COVID epidemic. Other factors driving the decision, which is expected to come soon, include reduced operating surpluses and concerns over declining international student applications.

This fall, Columbia enrolled its largest-ever first-year cohort, 1,806, nearly 20 percent more than the previous year.

California Regents Renew Tuition Plan. In November, the U. of California Regents renewed UC's Tuition Stability Plan that calls for tuition increases up to 5 percent per year for new undergraduates. The plan was originally passed in 2021 and went into effect in 2022 and is tied to inflation.

"Students from families earning under $120,000 annually have a lower average net cost of attendance than without the plan," a university spokesperson told the *Santa Barbara Independent*. "Only those from families earning more than $180,000 are expected to pay more—$41,400 compared to $40,700 annually."

In 1959, UC Regents voted to "reaffirm the long-established principle that state colleges and the University of California shall be tuition free to all residents of the state." But beginning in 1977, UC started charging tuition. UC undergraduate tuition and fees for the 2024–2025 academic year for California residents stood at $16,050, for nonresidents, $50,250 per year. Nearly 70 percent of California undergraduates get an average of $22,000 in grants and scholarships to help with costs, including UC tuition, food and housing, transportation, books and supplies.

Franklin and Marshall's "Commonwealth Commitment." Franklin & Marshall C. in Lancaster, Pennsylvania, launched its "Commonwealth Commitment" of free tuition for many Pennsylvania students. Tuition is free for students from families earning $75,000 or less and capped at no higher than Penn State's in-state tuition for students from families earning between $75,000 and $150,000.

"If you go to F&M, your earnings five and ten years out are substantially higher than graduates of Penn State, Pitt or Temple," said Andrew Rich, president.

Johns Hopkins Tuition Free. Starting next year, students from families earning under $200,000 a year will attend tuition free. Between 2018 and 2025, the percentage of low-income students in JHU's first-year class rose from 15.4 percent to 24.1 percent. the highest in university history.

Test-Free This Cycle at 90 Percent of Ranked Schools. According to the National Center for Fair & Open Testing (FairTest), "More than 90 percent of ranked four-year colleges and universities will not require applicants for Fall 2026 admissions to submit ACT/SAT scores…. Test-optional policies continue to dominate at national universities, state flagships and selective liberal arts colleges."

Among schools reaffirming their test-optional policies is the U. of Notre Dame.

"I don't think it's the most perfect indicator, but what I like about it being optional, not completely revoked, is that it gives kids who have the ability to score well to score well and let that shine on their application as well," Miki Kidder, vice president for undergraduate enrollment, told *The Observer.*

Notre Dame now also accepts 60 to 90-second Glimpse video submissions from InitialView. A Glimpse video costs $22, but the fee can be waived. ■

COUNSELOR'S BOOKSHELF

New from *The Chronicle of Higher Education*: "A.I. for the Student of Tomorrow" by Justin Reich; *Supporting Students in Turbulent Times* and *Building a Thriving Humanities Program*.

And, *Chronicle* Dataset. *"Degrees Conferred"* (which includes which degrees are most popular, which colleges grant the most degrees in specific disciplines, which degrees are most popular with women vs. men and so forth.

All available at https://store.chronicle.com.

National Student Aid Profile. "The National Profile provides detailed information about each of the programs authorized under Title IV of the Higher Education Act including descriptions of the federal student aid programs; updated data on the number of recipients, total volume of awards and average aid amount for each program; recent trends in federal appropriations for the Title IV programs; income levels of students and families who receive aid and a description of the federal student aid application process."

See, www.nasfaa.org/profile

Why Do Community College Students Leave School? "Nearly 40 percent of students in public two-year colleges do not return for their second year and have not earned a certificate or degree. Students who leave without earning a credential are unlikely to return. As a result, many students miss out on the socioeconomic benefits associated with completing a postsecondary credential…. New findings suggest that students rarely leave for a single reason, rather, departure decisions are shaped by a combination of factors, some of which could be addressed by colleges themselves."

See, "Why Did They Leave? Learning From the Experiences of Former Community College Students" from the Community College Research Center at Columbia U. See, https://www.ccrc.tc.columbia.edu.

"FAFSA Made Simple: Your Comprehensive Financial Aid Guide."

See, www.snappywords.com/knowledge.

(One of *CB*'s readers recommended "FAFSA Made Simple.") ■

CURRICULUM CAPSULES

Drew U. Creates "Radical" Tech-Driven School. Drew U. in New Jersey announced establishment of a "radical new school." The first cohort will launch spring 2026 with 12-15 current students devoting half of their course schedule to a program that Drew said will fast track their ability to design their own cross-disciplinary path of study, focusing their individual passions and learning to tackle real-world problems in real-time.

"We're building a radically different school - one cohort at a time," said President Hilary L. Link. "We will unleash the power of individual purpose by driving the future of learning through the use of ever evolving enabling technologies to promote access and center students working on urgent societal problems through deep mentorship, authentic engagement with real-world challenges and a broader definition of learning."

Eastern Washington's Three New Online Graduate Programs. Eastern Washington U. in Cheney, southwest of Spokane, launched three new online graduate programs: an M.S. in Organizational Leadership-Artificial Intelligence, an M.S. in Organizational Leadership-Change Leadership and a Master of Business Administration-Cybersecurity.

Rice's New Paris Program. Rice U. in Texas signed an agreement with Université Paris Sciences & Letters, establishing an "articulated undergraduate degree pathway," and a research partnership with the Paris Brain Institute, both building on its Rice Global Paris Center, opened in 2022. About 200 students a year participate in Rice's Paris programs.

Tribal Gaming and Hospitality. Southeastern Oklahoma State U. and the Tribal Education Initiative at the U. of Nevada Las Vegas announced a partnership to prepare students for careers in Tribal Gaming and Hospitality.

Southeastern Oklahoma State in Durant also has expanded its Special Education offering with a new graduate concentration in Autism and Developmental Disabilities. Shortages of Special Education teachers appear in 80 percent of the nation's school districts. ■

NEWS YOU CAN USE

Education Department Dismantled. As promised during his campaign, President Trump is dismantling the U.S. Department of Education. In mid-November, Ed sent several of its main offices to other federal agencies.

However, the $1.6 trillion student aid portfolio will remain in place. For now, ED will continue to supervise accreditation programs and support for students with disabilities, although those programs could be shifted to Health and Human Services.

The Department of Labor will now be responsible for dispersing $137.85 billion Title I funds to 18,200 elementary and secondary school districts and 50 million students.

The Department of Health and Human Services will be responsible for a grant program for parents attending college. The State Department will fund foreign language programs. The Department of the Interior will run Native American education programs. ED's reduced Office of Civil Rights has been assigned to the U.S. Department of Justice.

Is AI Scoring College Essays? The AP recently reported that "Colleges stress they are not relying on AI to make admissions decisions, using it primarily to review transcripts and eliminate data-entry tasks. But artificial intelligence also is playing a role in evaluating students.

Some highly-selective schools are adopting AI tools to vet the increasingly curated application packages that some students develop with the help of high-priced admissions consultants."

COMINGS AND GOINGS…

Rosemont C., a Catholic liberal arts college just outside of Philadelphia, will merge with **Villanova U.** in 2028. Fall enrollment at Rosemont tumbled by 48 percent to 428 students from 783 last year. Still, those students are engaged. "Classes are the most active, lively ones I've taught anywhere…," said one professor.

Sterling C. will close in Spring 2026. Sterling C., the environmentally focused school in Vermont founded in 1958, will close this coming spring. Its 124 undergraduates engaged in environmental studies, ecological agriculture and outdoor education will transfer to several colleges with "teach-out" agreements.

Trinity Christian C. in south suburban Chicago will close in May after 60 years. "The board has worked faithfully and tirelessly to consider every option in the face of rapidly evolving financial challenges. However, there is no path forward for our beloved institution," Acting President Jeanine Mozie told ABC 7 Chicago. ■

ENROLLMENT TRENDS

continued from page 2

Vermont State Gains. Vermont State U. enrolled 5,185 students in the fall, 1.4 percent more than last year. Online enrollment surged by 10 percent. VTSU's Lyndon and Williston campuses both experienced growth, 0.7 percent and 2 percent respectively. Its Early College program jumped by 7.5 percent.

Virginia's Class of 2029. The U. of Virginia welcomed 3,985 first-year students this fall. The admit rate this year was 16 percent, down from 23 percent in 2020. Over 20 percent qualified for Pell Grants and 19.6 are first-generation college students. The 12.5 percent of the class who are legacy students received no special treatment, following Virginia law. And 807 students transferred into the university.

Female students make up 55.2 percent of the Class of 2029. International students from 90 nations make up 5.9 percent of the new class, while African Americans account for 6.1 percent, down from 7.2 percent last year. Hispanics make up 9.1 percent of UVA's new class, Asian Americans 19 percent and multiracial students 6.2 percent.

Willamette Drew Fewer California Students. Willamette U. in Oregon attracted fewer first-year students, but more transfers and graduate students, according to *The Collegian*. Its undergraduate student body numbers 1,715 full-time students, 368 of whom are freshmen, down from 405 last fall.

This fall, 68 students transferred into the university versus 51 last fall. Total Willamette enrollment, including graduate students, reached 2,775.

Sue Corner, dean of undergraduate admissions, told the paper that Willamette usually enrolls more students from California than Oregon, but not this year. She attributed the difference to the effort of California to keep more college students in state.

However, a recent report from the Policy Institute of California found that the number of college bound California high school graduates enrolling in out-of-state schools nearly doubled in the last two decades from 8.5 percent to 14.5 percent. A third of them headed for Arizona, Oregon and New York. Oregon State U. attracted the most in that state.

Corner also said that Willamette is making resource-based decisions to combat demographic changes and that instead of cutting admissions positions to prepare for the "demographic cliff," it created transfer admissions roles to recruit new students. ■

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